to a peaceful equilibrium. Rajiv had knowledge of the intricacies of these operations.[90] Nonetheless, overtly he launched a grand diplomatic enterprise with the US and the Soviet Union.

To begin with, in January 1985, India hosted a meeting of the 'Delhi Six'—India, Argentina, Greece, Sweden, Mexico, and Tanzania—who issued the Delhi Declaration condemning an arms race emerging from Reagan's Strategic Defence Initiative.[91] Soon after, in May 1985, he visited Moscow, and, as put by a senior Congress party member, 'got practically everything from the USSR that it [India] had asked for'.[92] In November 1986, reformist Soviet leader Mikhail Gorbachev, who initiated Perestroika, visited India (the first of any Soviet president to a 'third world' country) to buttress bilateral relations, but more so, to check on Rajiv's progress on the Afghan question with Reagan. In early 1985 India's foreign secretary Romesh Bhandari had iterated to US Under Secretary of State William Schneider that while India would not get into 'the game of mediation', it will be willing to play a 'more active role' if Moscow did not object.[93] Though in CIA's confidential assessment New Delhi's private efforts to influence Moscow's decisions on Afghanistan had 'irritated' the Soviets, Gorbachev did not oppose India's diplomatic activism. Rajiv developed an active channel with both Reagan and Gorbachev between 1985 and 1988. It was meant to ensure a timely Soviet withdrawal and a moderate, non-aligned, political dispensation in Kabul. Rajiv's visit to Moscow and Washington in 1985 set the ball rolling. 'We want to try so that something starts moving [on Afghanistan]', Rajiv told a roomful of journalists before flying to the US.[94] With the UN process (under Diego Cordovez) stalemated for more than three years now, Reagan agreed that Rajiv's 'intervention with Secretary General Gorbachev was so much more timely'.[95]

Rajiv wanted to convince the US that a genuinely 'non-aligned' Afghanistan was in the best interest of both the US and India, and that the new Soviet president, Gorbachev, was serious about a timely exit.[96] On the other hand, he wanted Moscow to believe that the US was not bent on bleeding Moscow in Afghanistan with Pakistani support. Rajiv was the right candidate to execute this role. A young former pilot interested in modernisation and married to an Italian woman—Sonia Gandhi (née Maino)—he got along well with the Americans (especially then Vice President George H. W. Bush).[97] He was also the chairman